

THIS ISSUE TRAINS · COUNTING YOUR DEPENDENCIES

Money and markets

Gold touched an all time record near USD 4,379 per ounce in mid October 2025, as investors around the world paid up for the one major asset that is nobody's promise. Gold pays no interest and produces nothing, yet when people want certainty that does not depend on anyone keeping their word, it is where they go.

Almost everything else you will ever own, a bank deposit, a bond, a share, is a claim on someone: its value survives only as long as they deliver. The record was the market putting a price on not having to trust anybody.

The SCD takeaway: almost every asset is somebody's promise. Know whose, and what happens to its value when promises come into doubt.

Sources: USAGOLD 2025 policy review.

Engineering corner

Sunlight in, fresh water out. Researchers unveiled a solar desalination system that turns seawater into drinking water without producing brine, the salty waste conventional plants pump back into the sea. Laser textured metal panels absorb sunlight and drive the evaporation directly, converting the region's two great surpluses, seawater and sunshine, into the thing it lacks most.

The SCD takeaway: every input a system does not need is a failure it cannot have.

Source: ScienceDaily, May 30, 2026.

Your move

Counterparty risk is the chance that whoever is on the other side of a promise fails to deliver. Finance prices it constantly; engineering designs around it by removing dependencies altogether. The fewer promises a system needs to function, the fewer ways it can break.

This week, on your own: list three things you rely on every day. For each, write down whose promise has to hold for it to work. Then find the one that depends on nobody.